

Ethnic–Racial Socialization Measures for Parents of Migrant and Nonmigrant Descent in Germany

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Abstract: We developed new measures of ethnic–racial socialization for parents of migrant and nonmigrant descent in Germany, useful for much-needed studies on this topic. Our pre-registered study included 1,052 parents (50.5% migrant descent, 60% mothers) of school-aged children. Using exploratory and confirmatory factor analyses, initial results for separate scales showed that the item-loadings and factor structure for the two groups differed. Dimensions specific to migrant descent parents were *negotiating Germany's racist past and inequities*, *promotion of heritage culture*, and *preparation for bias*. Dimensions specific to nonmigrant parents were *questioning German (national) identity* and *German-regional socialization*. Subsequent analyses identified six common dimensions that included socialization regarding *egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *antiracism*, *critical consciousness*, and *promotion of mistrust*. The six dimensions demonstrated measurement invariance across migration status, gender, region, and educational status. We conclude that the scales demonstrate good psychometric properties and are appropriate for use in Germany and potentially other European countries.

Keywords: parent ethnic–racial socialization, scale development, migrant descent, nonmigrant descent

Background

Race and racism are an “absent presence” (M’charek et al., 2014), meaning that although in European contexts such as Germany, they may be pushed out of sight and not directly addressed, they are still present and influence our everyday lives (Deutsches Zentrum für Integrations- und Migrationsforschung [DeZIM], 2023). An important question then is how children grow up and make meaning of this “absent presence.” More specifically, in this particular context where “race” is taboo (Aikins et al., 2024), how do parents socialize their children to be aware of, reflect on, and address race-related issues and racism? In Germany, we know little (Juang, Schwarzenenthal, Aral, & Pevec, 2022). Therefore, our study focuses on German

parents and their ethnic–racial¹ socialization (ERS), the “behaviors, practices, and social regularities that implicitly or explicitly communicate information and worldviews about culture, ethnicity, and race” (D. L. Hughes et al., 2016, p. 4).

ERS research began in the United States with Black scholars examining how Black families protected their children to resist the harmful consequences of racism (Boykin & Toms, 1985). Since then, ERS research has expanded significantly, particularly in the United States (Atkin & Yoo, 2019; Huguley et al., 2019; Priest et al., 2014; Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020; M. T. Wang et al., 2020). In Germany, ERS has been studied in school (Schachner et al., 2021) and peer contexts (Schwarzenenthal et al., 2019; Vietze et al., 2019), and far less with regard to

¹ We use “racial” to indicate aspects of “race” such as skin color or other visible characteristics while acknowledging that “race” has *no scientific biological basis* but rather is a *relevant social construction* (Roig, 2017). Children with darker skin experience greater discrimination (Götz, 2021), those who perceive themselves as looking and sounding less like a “typical German” report greater discrimination (SVR Forschungsbereich, 2018), and Black Germans report that experiencing discrimination is mostly due to their ethnicity or skin color (Aikins et al., 2021).

how *families* engage in this important dimension of socialization. Notably, there are no quantitative measures of parent ERS developed in Germany or Europe, highlighting the need for new tools to study how parents in different parts of the world are socializing children growing up in diverse societies.

In this study, we developed and tested the psychometric properties of new measures of ERS for two groups: parents of migrant descent (i.e., having at least one parent not a German citizen at birth) and nonmigrant parents. We first adopted an emic approach, qualitatively by reviewing German-based literature and interviewing German young adults for a bottom-up understanding of ethnic–racial socialization experiences. We then quantitatively identified group-specific aspects of socialization based on different societal positioning (e.g., majority or minoritized, Aral et al., 2022) by conducting analyses separately for both groups. Then, we took an etic approach, identifying comparable aspects across groups to come up with a general measure relevant for both groups. Both emic and etic approaches to studying phenomena in different groups are important and can also be combined (Cheung et al., 2011).

Dimensions of Parent Ethnic–Racial Socialization

The original D. Hughes and Chen (1997) ERS scale, one of the most widely used measures, was developed for African American families and adapted for use with other ethnic–racial groups. Since then, four dimensions have been studied widely in the United States, namely, *cultural socialization* (passing along and maintaining heritage cultural traditions, values, and language), *preparation for bias* (preparing children for being the target of discrimination or negative expectations), *promotion of mistrust* (promoting caution and avoidance of outgroups that are perceived negatively), and *promotion of egalitarianism* (emphasizing all groups are equal and should be treated so; D. L. Hughes et al., 2016; Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). Beyond these four, other important dimensions are *appreciation for diversity* (emphasizing cultural pluralism as beneficial and supporting diverse friendships and perspectives; Juang et al., 2016) and *religious socialization* in terms of encouraging faith-based activities, values, and spirituality (Stevenson, 1994; Tuitt et al., 2023). A dimension that is particularly relevant to U.S. parents with migration histories is *becoming American* (e.g., participating in mainstream society; Juang et al., 2016; Y. Wang et al., 2015). More recently, a focus on U.S. White parent socialization distinguished two broad dimensions of ERS that are also observed among minoritized families: *color-evasion* (minimizing the relevance of racialization or

avoiding discussions of race and race-related issues) and *color consciousness* (addressing race and race-related issues; Hagan et al., 2024; Pahlke et al., 2012), which can include promotion of *critical consciousness* – an awareness of structural and institutional barriers and inequities that marginalize groups in society (Heberle et al., 2020).

Ethnic–Racial Socialization in Germany and Europe

Similar to parents in other inequitable societies, migrant descent parents in Germany may also prepare their children to live in a world where they face discrimination. Interviews with African-heritage German adults showed that they remembered their parents engaging in *preparation for bias and discrimination* as important strategies to resist anti-Black racism (Madubuko, 2017). Nurturing a sense of pride, belonging, and connection to one's cultural heritage (*cultural heritage socialization*) was an important community-building strategy to draw strength from (Madubuko, 2017). Similar to ERS studies in the United States, parents of immigrant communities in Germany encourage *becoming German* in terms of emphasizing the importance of German language use and celebrating mainstream traditions and holidays (Schachner et al., 2014). Concerning *religious socialization*, parents of Turkish heritage Muslim families in Germany encourage children to attend mosques, celebrate Ramadan, or learn values such as respecting the elderly (Uygun-Altunbaş, 2017). These few studies have taken an acculturation perspective, thus leaving out majority nonmigrant descent parents until recently.

For majority nonmigrant descent parents, two qualitative studies of ERS among White parents living in East and West Germany show that parents promote *appreciation for diversity* and also engage in silence about race and race-related issues (e.g., *color-evasion*) in part because these issues were deemed not relevant to their everyday lives (Kaiser et al., 2023, 2025). In the Netherlands, White Dutch mothers more so than Turkish or Black Dutch mothers also engage in color-evasion (avoiding mentioning skin color in a social categorization game) with their children (De Bruijn et al., 2025). Importantly, White Dutch mothers who did engage in color-conscious socialization had children who were less prejudiced (Mesman et al., 2022). Contrasting to migrant descent parents, nonmigrant majority parents in Germany may not emphasize socialization of a separate heritage culture (e.g., *heritage culture socialization*) as they may view ethnicity, heritage, and nationality as overlapping (Moffitt et al., 2018) and may not recognize themselves as having culture

(i.e., culture is something that “others” have), which is common among those of majority status (Gallagher et al., 2017). They may also believe their children should be shielded from discussions of racism (Kaiser et al., 2023, 2025), similar to findings with U.S. White families (Pahlke et al., 2012). Therefore, our scales include items for preparation for bias and maintenance of heritage culture for parents of migrant descent only.

ERS dimensions that are more German-specific and based on interview data with German youth (Aral & Juang, 2025; Schwarzensthal et al., 2025) and studies in Germany considering the particular sociohistorical context (e.g., Moffitt et al., 2018; Roig, 2017) include *acknowledgement of past and current racism* (to go beyond locating racism as only relevant during National Socialist times to also include contemporary racism in everyday life); *questioning German (national) identity*, especially for nonmigrant parents who may be socialized to be critical of identifying strongly with Germany due to its history (Seiffge-Krenke & Haid, 2012) compared to migrant descent parents who might be seen as not German enough; and *emphasizing regional socialization* (e.g., highlighting distinctions between East and West Germany or different regions). Germany was founded as a nation state in 1871, very recent compared to other European countries and which may partially explain strong regional identities and attachments.

Aims and Hypotheses

The first aim was to test the factor structure of the newly developed measures of parental ERS for each group (migrant descent and nonmigrant descent) separately. The second aim was to identify commonalities across the two groups to come up with a general measure. The third aim was to test psychometric qualities of the measures, including measurement invariance (across gender and region) and construct validity. One major deviation from our pre-registered study was including the second aim. Because some dimensions of ERS are relevant across diverse families and there is great heterogeneity within the broad categories of migrant versus nonmigrant, we chose to take this further step so that the same measure could be used more widely. Another major deviation was that we did not address H3 from our pre-registration which focused on substantive hypotheses (e.g., “For both groups, living in a more ethnically diverse neighborhood, having more friends of different backgrounds, engaging in antiracist actions, and more positive attitudes toward various ethnic and religious groups will relate positively to subscales that include color-consciousness socialization”). We decided it

made more sense in terms of focus and length to first report on the scale development and then report additional testing in a subsequent paper.

Based on our revised study aims, we had two hypotheses and one exploratory question.

Hypothesis 1 (H1): The Parent Ethnic–Racial Socialization Scale–Migrant Descent (PERS-M), Parent Ethnic–Racial Socialization Scale–Nonmigrant Descent (PERS-NM), and Parent Ethnic–Racial Socialization Scale–General (PERS-G) will show a multidimensional factor structure.

Hypothesis 2 (H2): The scales will demonstrate psychometric robustness in terms of reliability and validity (convergent and discriminant), and at least partial measurement invariance across gender and region.

Exploratory Question (E1): If there is enough variation in the sample collected, we will test for measurement invariance by educational status and by heritage group and generational status for migrant descent parents.

Method

Pre-registration of our hypotheses and proposed analyses can be found in an open repository <https://doi.org/10.23668/psycharchives.6677>. Data are publicly available at <https://doi.org/10.23668/psycharchives.12577>.

Procedure and Participants

Participants were recruited through the online panel provider Respondi in June/July 2022. The inclusion criteria were parents of school-aged children (6–17 years), living in Germany, and being comfortable filling out the survey in German. We used stratification sampling, aiming for 500 parents (300 mothers and 200 fathers) each of migrant and nonmigrant descent. A sample of $N = 300$ is sufficient for exploratory factor analyses (EFA, Worthington & Whittaker, 2006), and a minimum of $N = 100$ for each group is acceptable for multigroup confirmatory factor analysis (CFA) testing for measurement equivalence (Kline, 2016).

The study was approved by the University of Potsdam Ethics Committee. After providing informed consent, participants completed a 20–30 minute online questionnaire. Compensation for participation was funded by the

ZPID PsychLab and provided through Respondi. Our final sample included $N = 1,052$ parents who had on average 1.91 children ($SD = 0.88$). About half ($n = 531$) were of migrant descent ($n = 323$ mothers, $n = 208$ fathers, $M_{age} = 39.90$, $SD_{age} = 7.35$, 43% first generation, 35% second, 22% third). Most (56%) grew up in West Germany, 17% in East Germany, 21% abroad, 6% other, and 51% had a university degree. The other half ($n = 521$) were of nonmigrant descent ($n = 305$ mothers, $n = 216$ fathers, $M_{age} = 42.85$, $SD_{age} = 7.55$). Most (67%) grew up in West Germany, 31% in East Germany, 2% other, and 33% had a university degree. In Electronic Supplemental Material 1 [ESM 1], see Note E1 for initial sample and reasons for deleting cases, Table E1 for heritage groups of migrant descent parents, and Note E2 for cultural self-identifications of both groups.

Measures

Parental Ethnic–Racial Socialization

To develop measures tailored to the German context, we invested heavily in the front-end development of items (Gehlbach & Brinkworth, 2011) by taking three steps: (1) reviewed ERS literature (Aral et al., 2022; Juang, Schwarzenhal, Aral, & Pevec, 2022), (2) interviewed 19 majority and 29 minoritized (Turkish, Kurdish, East and Southeast Asian, African-heritage) youth who grew up in Germany (Aral & Juang, 2025; Schwarzenhal et al., 2025), see Note E1 in ESM 1 for a summary of the themes), and (3) consulted four expert reviewers after developing the initial set of items. Based on this preliminary work, we included items for 13 dimensions of parent ERS: (1) preparation for bias (for migrant descent parents only), (2) avoidance and mistrust of outgroups, (3) egalitarianism, (4) pluralistic orientation, (5) maintenance of heritage cultures (for migrant descent parents only), (6) being and becoming German, (7) religious socialization, (8) color-evasion, (9) critical consciousness, (10) acknowledgement of racism in the past, (11) acknowledgement of racism in the present, (12) questioning German (national) identity, and (13) emphasizing regional identities.

Four experts who research family socialization in the United States, the Netherlands, or Germany and were ethnic–racially diverse reviewed the 13 dimensions and items for clarity and were asked to suggest additional dimensions or items if they felt something was missing. Based on the review, 14 items and an additional dimension (dealing with differences between East and West Germany) were added. We further deleted 14 items due to overlapping content or less relevance for younger children (e.g., referring to dating).

This resulted in 96 items capturing 14 dimensions for the PERS-M and 75 items capturing 12 dimensions for the

PERS-NM (see Table E2 in ESM 1 for a list of all items). Parents were asked how often they engaged in each socialization item and responded on a scale from (1) *not at all*, (2) *rarely*, (3) *sometimes*, (4) *often*, to (5) *almost always*.

Validation Measures

Convergent Validity

Diversity Beliefs

Five items measured diversity beliefs (e.g., “It is good for German society that people from different cultures live here”; Adesokan et al., 2011), with a response scale from (1) *do not agree at all* to (5) *totally agree*, $\omega = .93$. A mean score was calculated such that a higher score indicated more positive diversity beliefs.

Colorblind Attitudes

Two types were assessed. Four items measured color-evasion in terms of ignoring cultural differences (e.g., “It is important to ignore cultural differences”; Civitillo et al., 2021), $\omega = .79$. Six items measured power-evasion, or the denial and unawareness of racism (e.g., “Racist problems are rare, isolated situations in Germany”; Neville et al., 2000), $\omega = .86$. The response scale for both measures ranged from (1) *do not agree at all* to (5) *totally agree*. Mean scores were calculated such that a higher score indicated more colorblind attitudes.

Discriminant Validity

Parental Warmth

Four items captured how often parents engaged in warm behaviors toward their children (e.g., “You show your children with words and gestures that you like them”; Grätz et al., 2022), with a response scale ranging from (1) *not at all* to (5) *almost always*, $\omega = .79$. A mean score was calculated such that a higher score indicated greater parental warmth.

Analytic Approach

To test the factor structure of the scales (H1), we followed the guidelines of Worthington and Whittaker (2006). We randomly selected a portion of each parent sample ($n_{\text{parents of migrant descent}} = 297$; 38% fathers; $n_{\text{parents of nonmigrant descent}} = 300$; 40% fathers) to conduct separate EFAs using an oblique rotation in RStudio. We used the rest ($n_{\text{parents of migrant descent}} = 234$; 40.6% fathers; $n_{\text{parents of nonmigrant descent}} = 221$; 43.4% fathers) for CFAs in Mplus (Muthén & Muthén, 2011) using maximum likelihood estimation with robust standard errors and Full Information Maximum Likelihood (FIML) to handle missing data. We conducted correlated factors CFA.

Regarding psychometric properties, we tested for reliability, convergent and discriminant validity, and measurement invariance. Reliability was assessed using

McDonald's ω (acceptable reliability criteria was $\omega > .70$). To test for convergent validity, we used bivariate correlations with the PERS subscales, diversity beliefs, and colorblind attitudes. We expected that diversity beliefs would generally be positively correlated with the PERS subscales except for avoidance and mistrust of outgroups and color-evasion. We expected that colorblind attitudes would be positively correlated with the PERS subscales of color-evasion and negatively with critical consciousness and acknowledgement of racism in the past and present. To test for discriminant validity, we used bivariate correlations with the PERS subscales and parental warmth. We expected weaker correlations with parental warmth compared to diversity beliefs and colorblind attitudes. The criterion for significance of coefficients was $p < .05$. To test for measurement equivalence across demographics (e.g., mother vs. father and East vs. West Germany) for each subscale, we first established configural invariance, followed by metric and scalar invariance, comparing the fit of metric versus configural models and scalar versus metric models. For more detail regarding criteria for invariance and analytic approach, please see the pre-registration.

Results

We conducted descriptive analyses on all variables, checking for missing data, skewness, and kurtosis. There were few item-level missing data (minimum 0.1% to maximum 1.6% per item). Skewness and kurtosis for all items were < 2 .

EFA and CFA for PERS-M (Parents of Migrant Descent)

Of 96 items used for EFA (see Table E19 in ESM 1 for interitem correlations), we removed five items due to high correlation ($> .80$); thus, 91 items remained. The KMO measure of sampling adequacy ($KMO = .94$) was above the recommended value (above .70) and Bartlett's sphericity test was satisfactory [$\chi^2(90) = 358.14, p < .001$]. In support of H1, the scree plot indicated seven factors and a parallel analysis resulted in eight factors. We then ran an eight-factor model with 91 items. Fourteen items were removed because of low factor loadings ($< .40$), high cross-loadings ($> .30$), or the low difference between primary loading and cross-loading ($< .20$). After removing these items, the model did not fit for an eight-factor EFA model; therefore, we then performed a seven-factor EFA model. Four items were removed due to high cross-loadings. The seven-factor model with 73 items explained 63% of the variance with eigenvalues ranging from 12.20 to 2.56 (see Table E3 in ESM 1 for factor loadings).

Using 73 items based on the EFA results, we conducted CFA using a stepwise approach (i.e., testing one factor, then adding other factors one by one) and deleted 17 additional items because of high correlations with other items, low factor loading, or reflecting a high conceptual overlap. The seven-factor model (see Table E4 in ESM 1) with 56 items did not show sufficient fit, $\chi^2(234) = 2,804.270, p < .000$, RMSEA = .060, 90% CI = [.057, .064]; CFI = .880; TLI = .874, and SRMR = .084. We then tested *preparation for bias* items—which initially formed a factor with *promotion of mistrust* items—as separate factors as they are conceptually different. This eight-factor model had a better model fit, $\chi^2(234) = 2,496.711, p < .000$, RMSEA = .053, 90% CI = [.049, .056]; CFI = .908; TLI = .903, and SRMR = .075 (see Table E5 in ESM 1 for final items, standardized factor loadings, and reliabilities of subscales, with items in English and German). The subscales were: *egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *critical consciousness*, *negotiating Germany's racist past and inequities*, *promotion of mistrust*, *heritage culture*, and *preparation for bias*. All subscales showed good reliability and were positively correlated ($r_s = 0.23\text{--}0.79$) except for a nonsignificant correlation between promotion of mistrust with egalitarian/pluralistic socialization. Bivariate correlations conducted for convergent and discriminant validity indicated that the PERS-M subscales were more weakly (or not) correlated to parental warmth compared to diversity beliefs and colorblind attitudes (see Table E6 in ESM 1 for all correlations and Table E16 in ESM 1 for additional partial correlations with factor scores). PERS-M demonstrated configural, metric, and scalar invariance across gender, region (East vs. West Germany), educational status, and generational status (Table E12 in ESM 1). The heritage groups sample sizes were too small to conduct measurement invariance tests. In support of H2 and E1, the scale demonstrated good psychometric properties.

EFA and CFA for PERS-NM (Parents of Nonmigrant Descent)

Of 75 items, we removed seven items due to high correlation with other items; thus, 68 items remained. The KMO measure of sampling adequacy ($KMO = .94$) was above the recommended value and Bartlett's sphericity test was satisfactory [$\chi^2(67) = 363.15, p < .001$]. In support of H1, the scree plot and the parallel analysis resulted in eight factors. We then ran an eight-factor EFA model. Twenty-one items were removed because of low factor loadings, high cross-loadings, or the low difference between primary loading and cross-loading. The eight-factor EFA model with 54 items explained 65% of the variance with eigenvalues ranging from 7.75 to 1.66 (see Table E7 in ESM 1 for factor loadings).

Using 54 items based on the EFA results, we conducted CFA using a stepwise approach and deleted 15 items because of high correlations with other items, low factor loading, or reflecting a high conceptual overlap. An 8-factor model with 39 items fit well, $\chi^2(221) = 1,208.559$, $p < .000$, RMSEA = .060, 90% CI = [.054, .065]; CFI = .917; TLI = .909, and SRMR = .078 (see Table E8 in ESM 1 for standardized factor loadings and reliabilities of subscales, with items in English and German). The subscales were: *egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *critical consciousness*, *current and past racism*, *promotion of mistrust*, *questioning German (national) identity*, and *German-regional*. All subscales showed good reliability and were positively correlated ($r_s = 0.13$ to 0.77) except for non-significant correlations for promotion of mistrust with egalitarian/pluralistic socialization, critical consciousness with German-regional (for mothers), and questioning national identity with German-regional (for fathers). Bivariate correlations conducted for convergent and discriminant validity indicated that the PERS-NM subscales were more weakly (or not) correlated with parental warmth compared to diversity beliefs and colorblind attitudes (see Table E9 in ESM 1 for all correlations and Table E17 in ESM 1 for additional partial correlations with factor scores). PERS-NM demonstrated configural, metric, and scalar invariance across gender, region, and educational status (Table E12 in ESM 1). In support of H2 and E1, the scale demonstrated good psychometric properties.

Selecting Common Subscales and CFA for PERS-G (General)

To identify items that could be used across both groups, we chose the subscales and items (6 subscales, 27 items) that were common to both parents of migrant and nonmigrant descent. Using the total sample reserved for CFA ($n = 455$), we ran a six-factor model CFA with 27 items. The model fit was good, $\chi^2(309) = 796.008$, $p < .000$, RMSEA = .059, 90% CI = [.054, .064]; CFI = .947; TLI = .940, and SRMR = .081 (see Table E10 in ESM 1 for standardized factor loadings and reliabilities of the subscales, with items in English and German). The subscales were: *egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *critical consciousness*, *antiracism*, and *promotion of mistrust* (see Appendix A and Appendix B for the PERS-G items in English and German, respectively). All subscales were positively correlated ($r_s = 0.21$ to 0.72) except for a nonsignificant correlation between promotion of mistrust with egalitarian/pluralistic socialization. Bivariate correlations conducted for convergent and discriminant validity indicated that the PERS-G subscales were more weakly (or not) correlated with parental warmth compared to

diversity beliefs and colorblind attitudes (Table E11 in ESM 1). PERS-G demonstrated configural, metric, and scalar invariance across migration status, gender, region, and educational status (Table E12 in ESM 1). In support of H2 and E1, the scale demonstrated good psychometric properties. Using ANOVAs, the results showed that parents of migrant descent scored higher across all PERS-G subscales compared to nonmigrant parents (Table E13 in ESM 1).

Discussion

Our aim was to develop new measures of parent ERS suitable for use in Germany. Such measures are needed to better document, for instance, how parents prepare their children for life in diverse societies as well as handle experiences of discrimination and racism. A representative study of German children reported that those who are minoritized and with darker skin experience more racism at young ages, and this increases with age (Götz, 2021). Understanding how minoritized and majority parents socialize their children through this reality, both to cope with and resist against continued societal inequities, is needed.

Based on our interviews, reviews of literature, and initial analyses testing the two parent groups separately (emic approach), there are eight socialization dimensions for migrant descent parents in the PERS-M (*egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *critical consciousness*, *negotiating Germany's racist past and inequities*, *promotion of mistrust*, *heritage culture*, *preparation for bias*) and eight for nonmigrant descent parents in the PERS-NM (*egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *critical consciousness*, *current and past racism*, *promotion of mistrust*, *questioning German (national) identity*, and *German-regional*). The results show both similarities as well as differences in factor loadings across the two parent groups, particularly with regards to items capturing historical and current racism. For parents of migrant descent, items regarding racism during the Holocaust and during colonial times, discussing the history of divided (East and West) Germany, and questioning German identity all loaded on the same factor. In sharp contrast, for nonmigrant parents, items questioning German (national) identity loaded on its own factor and the items for racism during the Holocaust (but not colonialism) loaded on the *current and past racism* factor. This variation in factor structures may reflect differences in experiences of migrant descent and nonmigrant descent parents. For parents of migrant descent, negotiating German identities, grappling with colonial history, and everyday racism appear to be more intertwined than for nonmigrant parents. Furthermore, for

PERS-M, heritage culture socialization and preparation for bias are separate subscales, and for PERS-NM, German-regional socialization is a separate subscale. The final items reflect the intended constructs, but with some variations. For researchers who focus on one group and do not want to compare across groups, using these tailored versions with nonidentical factor structures and item loadings may be preferable as they capture experiences that are more specific to each group.

In addition to developing scales separately, we also identified items and factors meaningful for both groups (etic approach) to have a general measure (PERS-G) with six common dimensions that were measurement invariant across both parent groups: *egalitarianism/pluralism*, *color-evasion*, *religion*, *critical consciousness*, *antiracism*, and *promotion of mistrust*. Thus, if researchers are interested in comparing across migrant status groups, this streamlined scale with six dimensions and fewer items is appropriate. Future research could also test whether this general scale may be useful for studies in other parts of Europe that may share similar sociohistorical features.

Some dimensions we identified in Germany are similar to what is found in the United States, such as promoting and valuing equality, promotion of mistrust, color-evasion, preparation of bias, and maintaining heritage culture ties for migrant descent parents (Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). These dimensions may be common across countries that are ethnic–racially diverse and have a history of systemic racism and continued inequities. For instance, in Germany, Europe, and North America, ethnic–racially minoritized groups are more likely to experience discrimination and show disparities in education, housing, the labor market, and health compared to the White majority nonmigrant population (e.g., DeZIM, 2023; European Union Agency for Fundamental Rights, 2017; Kelly, 2022; OECD, 2023). Parents raising their children in these contexts may rely on similar strategies to prepare for bias and confront racism, reduce intergroup tensions, and support connections to one's ethnic community for strength and a sense of belonging. Newer studies from the Netherlands (Mesman et al., 2022) and China (Shen et al. 2021) also show across-country similarities in terms of parents engaging in color-conscious practices, cultural socialization, promotion of mistrust, and preparation for bias. We note that in those studies, however, measures adapted from the United States were used and no new items for the particular country were developed. It would be useful to do so to uncover and show the spectrum of ERS practices across the globe. Assessing parental ERS more precisely and comprehensively will allow for a better understanding of what specific aspects of ERS may be protective for youth identities and adjustment as well as promotive in terms of awareness of and resistance to racism.

Regarding the common six dimensions, what do parents in Germany do to make meaning of the “absent presence” (M'charek et al., 2014) of race-related issues and racism? For both migrant and nonmigrant descent parents, they reported being most engaged in promoting equality and valuing diversity, and least engaged in promotion of mistrust, similar to U.S. studies (Umaña-Taylor & Hill, 2020). Across dimensions, the mean scores ranged from 1.68 to 3.60 with most falling between 2 (rarely) and 3 (sometimes), indicating rather low frequencies of ERS. Overall, parents of migrant descent reported engaging in all dimensions at greater frequency than those of nonmigrant descent. Because children of migrant descent experience greater discrimination than those of nonmigrant descent (Götz, 2021), their parents may necessarily engage in more explicit ERS. Indeed, some majority nonmigrant descent parents in former East and West Germany see racism as irrelevant to their children, making it a lower priority in socialization (Kaiser et al., 2023, 2025).

Regarding the validation measures, we included parental warmth, diversity beliefs, and two different types of colorblind attitudes: ignoring ethnicity/race (color-evasion) and ignoring structural racism (power-evasion or unawareness of blatant racial issues; Neville et al., 2000). As expected, parental warmth was correlated more weakly (or not at all) with the PERS subscales compared to diversity beliefs or colorblind attitudes, providing some evidence of discriminant validity. Interestingly, parental warmth was positively correlated with egalitarian/pluralism and negatively with promotion of mistrust, in line with studies in which parental (i.e., maternal) warmth was correlated negatively with in-group bias in children (Jugert et al., 2016) and with increases in children and adolescents' prosocial behaviors over time (Pastorelli et al., 2021). Parents who are warm and supportive may be modeling and encouraging acceptance of diverse others, an important aspect of prosocial attitudes.

Most ERS dimensions, except promotion of mistrust, correlated positively with diversity beliefs and colorblind attitudes. The negative correlation between promotion of mistrust and diversity beliefs aligns with the idea that viewing other groups as threats may reduce openness to diversity. In contrast, parents promoting more egalitarianism/pluralism, color-evasion, and religion and critical consciousness socialization reported more positive diversity beliefs. The positive correlation between color-evasion socialization and diversity beliefs is similar to previous studies in Germany (Schachner et al., 2021; Schwarzenenthal et al., 2020) and a meta-analysis of colorblind attitudes with diversity ideologies (Yi et al., 2023). Although color-evasion may signal a desire for an equitable society where ethnicity–race does not matter for opportunities or well-being (Knowles et al., 2009), promoting color-evasion should come with caution, as children

socialized with color-evasion may be more likely to overlook racial discrimination (Apfelbaum et al., 2010) and thus be less likely to act against it.

A few correlation patterns are difficult to interpret, such as unexpected positive correlations between critical consciousness and antiracism socialization with unawareness of racial issues (power-evasion). Due to our nonrepresentative sample, we are uncertain whether these correlations are sample-specific or if there are moderators that could explain them. We attempted to ensure fidelity of the data by screening for careless responding (e.g., checking for straight-lining, using attention checks, deleting nonsensical or suspicious responses). More studies to better understand these puzzling correlations are needed. As most correlation patterns make sense, we tentatively conclude that our scale is measuring the intended constructs.

Limitations

Our study has some limitations, including the nonrepresentative sample which was more highly educated than the general population. Our sample was also biased to those parents willing to fill out a questionnaire regarding “taboo” topics. To better understand parent responses, we included one open-ended question at the end of the survey, asking parents if they had anything else to say about the survey. Almost half (44.7%) responded (see Table E14 in ESM 1 for more details on coding and examples). Of these responses, 47.8% were neutral (e.g., “It was ok”), and 15.7% were negative about the survey or held racist views (e.g., “Why are we Germans being accused of permanent racism?”). A few (3.8%) felt these issues were not relevant to their own families (e.g., “my children are not interested in such topics and they are not a topic of conversation in our house”), and a few (3.8%) expressed views that were color-evasive (e.g., “origin is not important, being human is”). However, some parents (14%) were positive about the survey (e.g., “a very important topic that is dealt with far too little in society”) and a few (3.2%) were inspired to think more about these issues (e.g., “some of the questions made me think that we should already talk about these things even if they are young, to make them aware”). From these responses, we conclude that issues of ERS are a very important area that (some) parents would also like to know more about.²

Another limitation is the binary of splitting the sample into migrant and nonmigrant descent parents. We recognize the limitations of this dichotomy, which has the danger of homogenizing and essentializing these broad

groupings and does not show the heterogeneity within. White nonmigrant descent parents from East versus West Germany engage in ERS slightly differently (Kaiser et al., 2023, 2025), with a sample of parents in West Germany being less hesitant to talk about race and racism and some acknowledging privileges of whiteness, which was not evident with a sample of parents in East Germany. These are good examples of the necessity to consider within group heterogeneity to more accurately capture what is happening. The binary categorization by migration status also does not account for racialization. Some parents with migrant descent can also be read as White and their experiences and socialization may be more similar to that of White, majority, nonmigrant descent parents than to that of Turkish heritage parents, for example.

Conclusion

The study of ERS in Germany would benefit from measurement scales developed with the specific socio-historical context in mind. Our study with migrant and nonmigrant descent parents shows both similar and unique dimensions of ERS in Germany compared to the broader ERS literature which mainly originates from the United States, as well as similar and unique dimensions of ERS among parents of migrant and nonmigrant descent. If researchers are interested in factors specific to each group, using the PERS-M (Table E5 in ESM 1) or PERS-NM (Table E8 in ESM 1) is suitable. If group comparisons are of focus, the PERS-G (Appendix A and Appendix B) is appropriate. Overall, the scales demonstrate good psychometric properties and are appropriate for use in Germany and potentially other European countries. In increasingly diverse and persistently inequitable societies, understanding how parents are raising their children regarding racism and related issues, to resist against or continue to uphold inequities, is an important direction for future research.

Electronic Supplementary Material

The following electronic supplementary material is available at <https://doi.org/10.1027/2151-2604/a000589>
ESM 1. Details on sample, items, bivariate and partial correlations, and measurement invariance testing.

ESM 2. Inter-item correlations of all items in German.

² We tested whether parents responding in these different ways (neutral, negative, not relevant, color-evasive, positive, and inspired to think more) correlated with the subscales, but they did not.

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History

Received August 15, 2024

Revision received December 19, 2024

Accepted December 20, 2024

Published online September 8, 2025

Acknowledgments

The authors wish to thank Elma Lorenzo-Blanco, Birgit Leyendecker, Nkechi Madubuko, and Diana van Bergen for their expert reviews regarding scale items in the initial development phase.

Publication Ethics

All procedures in studies involving human participants were performed in accordance with the ethical standards of University of Potsdam's Human Research Ethics Committee (Reference #84/2020).

Appendix A

Parental Ethnic–Racial Socialization Scale-General (PERS-G)

This scale is suitable for use when both migrant-descent and nonmigrant descent parents are included and compared in a study. If the study focuses only on migrant-descent parents, we recommend using PERS-M (Table E5

Authorship

All three authors share first authorship. Linda P. Juang, funding acquisition, writing – original draft of introduction and discussion, review and editing; Tuğçe Aral, funding acquisition, formal data analysis, data curation, writing – original draft of results, review & editing; Miriam Schwarzenenthal, funding acquisition, writing – original draft of methods, review and editing.

Open Science

Data are embargoed and will be publicly available in 2026 at <https://doi.org/10.23668/psycharchives.15926> (Aral et al., 2025). This study and analysis plan were pre-registered at <https://doi.org/10.23668/psycharchives.6677> (Juang, Schwarzenenthal, & Aral, 2022).

Funding

This research was supported by a ZPID, Leibniz Institut für Psychologie, grant to Linda P. Juang, Miriam Schwarzenenthal, and Tuğçe Aral. Open access publication enabled by University of Potsdam.

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in ESM 1) and for nonmigrant descent parents, using PERS-NM (Table E8 in ESM 1).

Instructions to parents in filling out the survey items: “We are interested in what parents discuss and do with their children in everyday life on topics such as heritage, culture, and religion. Please read each of the following points and indicate how often you do or discuss the following things with your children. The response scale ranges from 1 = *not at all*, 2 = *rarely*, 3 = *sometimes*, 4 = *often*, 5 = *almost always* (Table A1).

Table A1. Items for Parental Ethnic–Racial Socialization Scale-General (PERS-G)

1 Not at all	2 Rarely	3 Sometimes	4 Often	5 Almost always
How often...				
Egalitarianism/Pluralism		... do you tell your child that all people are equal, regardless of their origins or cultural backgrounds? ... do you mention to your child that a person's origins or cultural backgrounds are not important when choosing friends? ... do you teach your child to treat all people with respect regardless of their origins or cultures? ... do you make an effort to ensure that your child can spend time with people from other origins or cultural backgrounds? ... do you tell your child that stereotypes/prejudices toward people with different origins or cultures should be avoided?		
Color evasion		... do you tell your child that there is no racism in Germany? ... do you mention to your child that people who talk about racism are just too sensitive? ... do you tell your child that racism is a thing of the past?		
Religion		... do you teach your child about the values of your family's religion? ... do you take your child to a religious institution (e.g., mosque, church, or synagogue) to learn about your religion? ... do you explain something that happened in everyday life with God or God's will?		
Critical consciousness		... do you discuss with your child that people of different origins or cultures do not always have the same opportunities in Germany? ... do you mention to your child that people who speak German with a "foreign" accent are more likely to be discriminated against at school or in the workplace? ... do you mention to your child that someone without an immigrant background in Germany has more advantages in life? ... do you mention to your child that White people around the world enjoy privileges? ... do you tell your child that someone without an immigrant background might be treated better at school and in the workplace in Germany?		
Antiracism		... do you tell your child about racism during the Holocaust? ... do you encourage your child to be antifascist or antiright wing to distance themselves from Germany's past? ... do you visit places of remembrance of the Holocaust with your child (e.g., Holocaust memorials, museums, or Stolpersteine)? ... do you talk to your child about racism in everyday life? ... do you talk to your child about how racism can be subtle/subliminal?		
Promotion of mistrust		... do you tell your child that they cannot trust people of certain origins, cultures, or religions? ... do you tell your child that people of certain origins, cultures, or religions will never be able to integrate into German society? ... do you tell your child to avoid certain parts of town because many people of certain origins, cultures, or religions live there? ... do you talk to your child about how certain cultures or religions are a threat to German society? ... do you express that people of certain origins, cultures, or religions fit better into German society than others? ... do you make jokes about people of certain origins, cultures, or religions in Germany in the presence of your child?		

Appendix B

Elterliche Skala für kulturelle und rassismusbezogene Sozialisation - Allgemein (PERS-G)

Diese Skala ist geeignet, wenn sowohl Eltern mit familiärer Migrationsgeschichte als auch Eltern ohne familiäre Migrationsgeschichte in eine Studie einbezogen und verglichen werden. Wenn sich die Studie nur auf Eltern mit familiärer Migrationsgeschichte konzentriert, empfehlen

wir die Verwendung von PERS-M (Tabelle E5 in ESM 1) und für Eltern ohne familiäre Migrationsgeschichte die Verwendung von PERS-NM (Tabelle E8 in ESM 1).

Anleitung für Eltern zum Ausfüllen der Umfrage: Uns interessiert, was Eltern im Alltag mit ihren Kindern zu Themen wie Herkunft, Kultur und Religion besprechen und tun. Bitte lesen Sie jeden der folgenden Punkte und geben Sie an, wie häufig Sie die folgenden Dinge mit Ihren Kindern tun oder besprechen. Die Antwortskala: 1 = *gar nicht*, 2 = *selten*, 3 = *manchmal*, 4 = *oft*, 5 = *fast immer* (Table B1).

Table B1. Items der Elterlichen Skala für kulturelle und rassismusbezogene Sozialisation - Allgemein (PERS-G)

1	2	3	4	5
gar nicht	selten	manchmal	oft	fast immer
		Wie oft...		
Egalitarismus/Pluralismus		... erzählen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass alle Menschen gleich sind, unabhängig von ihren Herkunftsn oder ihren kulturellen Hintergründen? ... erwähnen Sie Ihrem Kind gegenüber, dass die Herkunftsn oder die kulturellen Hintergründe einer Person bei der Wahl der Freund:innen nicht wichtig sind? ... lehren Sie Ihr Kind, allen Menschen unabhängig von ihren Herkunftsn oder Kulturen mit Respekt zu begegnen? ... bemühen Sie sich darum, dass Ihr Kind Zeit mit Menschen mit anderen Herkunftsn oder kulturellen Hintergründen verbringen kann? ... erzählen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass Stereotype/Vorurteile gegenüber Menschen mit anderen Herkunftsn oder Kulturen vermieden werden sollten?		
Farbenblindheit		... erzählen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass es in Deutschland keinen Rassismus gibt? ... erwähnen Sie Ihrem Kind gegenüber, dass Leute, die über Rassismus reden, einfach zu empfindlich sind? ... sagen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass Rassismus der Vergangenheit angehört?		
Religion		... bringen Sie Ihrem Kind etwas über die Werte der Religion Ihrer Familie bei? ... bringen Sie Ihr Kind in eine religiöse Einrichtung (z.B. Moschee, Kirche, Synagoge), um etwas über Ihre Religion zu erfahren? ... erklären Sie etwas, das im Alltag passiert ist, mit Gott oder Gottes Willen?		
Kritisches Bewusstsein		... diskutieren Sie mit ihrem Kind darüber, dass Menschen verschiedener Herkunftsn oder Kulturen in Deutschland nicht immer die gleichen Chancen haben? ... erwähnen Sie Ihrem Kind gegenüber, dass Menschen, die Deutsch mit einem "ausländischen" Akzent sprechen, in der Schule oder am Arbeitsplatz eher diskriminiert werden? ... erwähnen Sie Ihrem Kind gegenüber, dass jemand ohne Zuwanderungsgeschichte in Deutschland mehr Vorteile im Leben hat? ... erwähnen Sie Ihrem Kind gegenüber, dass weiße Menschen auf der ganzen Welt Privilegien genießen? ... erzählen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass jemand ohne Zuwanderungsgeschichte in Deutschland in der Schule und am Arbeitsplatz möglicherweise besser behandelt wird?		

(Continued on next page)

Table B1. (Continued)

1 gar nicht	2 selten	3 manchmal	4 oft	5 fast immer
Rassismuskritik		... erzählen Sie Ihrem Kind etwas über den Rassismus während des Holocausts? ... ermutigen Sie Ihr Kind, antifaschistisch oder antirechtsextremistisch^a zu sein, um sich von der deutschen Vergangenheit zu distanzieren? ... besuchen Sie mit Ihrem Kind Orte des Andenkens an den Holocaust (z.B. Holocaust-Gedenkstätten, Museen, Stolpersteine)? ... sprechen Sie mit Ihrem Kind über Rassismus im Alltagsleben? ... sprechen Sie mit Ihrem Kind darüber, dass Rassismus subtil/ unterschwellig sein kann?		
Förderung von Misstrauen		... sagen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass es Menschen bestimmter Herkunft, Kulturen oder Religionen nicht vertrauen kann? ... erzählen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass Menschen bestimmter Herkunft, Kulturen oder Religionen nie in der Lage sein werden, sich in die deutsche Gesellschaft zu integrieren? ... sagen Sie Ihrem Kind, dass es bestimmte Stadtteile meiden soll, weil dort viele Menschen bestimmter Herkunft, Kulturen oder Religionen leben? ... reden Sie mit Ihrem Kind darüber, dass bestimmte Kulturen oder Religionen eine Bedrohung für die deutsche Gesellschaft darstellen? ... bringen Sie zum Ausdruck, dass Menschen bestimmter Herkunft, Kulturen oder Religionen besser in die deutsche Gesellschaft passen als andere? ... machen Sie in der Gegenwart Ihres Kindes Witze über Menschen bestimmter Herkunft, Kulturen oder Religionen in Deutschland?		

Anmerkung. ^aWir hatten "anti-right wing" in unserer Skala mit "anti-rechts" übersetzt, schlagen aber vor, für eine eindeutige Formulierung in Zukunft "anti-rechtsextremistisch" zu verwenden.